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History Grade -12

Unit- Five

Italian Fascists Aggression Against Ethiopia (1935-1941)

- This unit includes the following sub-topics
  - 5.1 Background and causes of the Italo-Ethiopian war of 1935-1936
  - 5.2 The Italo-Ethiopian war,1935-1936
  - 5.3.Fascist Occupation and Patriotic Resistance,1936-1941
  - 5.4. The war of Liberation and Ethiopian Independence
    - Today lesson only 5.1 and 5.2

- **After the end of this lesson ,you will be able to:-**
  - **Explain the causes of Italo-Ethiopian war**
  - **Mention the European ambition in Ethiopia after the illness of Menelik II in 1906.**
  - **Analyze the causes of the 1935 Italian aggression Ethiopia.**
  - **Explain about the course and consequence of Italo- Ethiopian war.**

5.1. **Background and causes of the Italo-Ethiopian war of 1935-1936**

5.1.1. European ambitions in Ethiopia in the post –Adwa Period.

- European government revived their colonial interest over Ethiopia in the first **decade of 20th century**.
  - By 1906 tripartite treaty among ***Britain, France and Italy.***
    - To divide and colonize Ethiopia when opportunity comes.
  - **France** interested in territories along the Railway line pass of Addis Ababa-Djibouti.
  - **Britain** along Abay and Lake Tana areas and
  - **Italy** in the hinter lands of south of Eretria and north of Italian-Somaliland.

- Menlik II learned about the treaty, he made legitimate protest. But his protest passed unheeded on the part of Europeans.
- In order to ensure the smooth continuity of government and peaceful succession he took the following two steps ;-
  - 1907 established a cabinet of ministers
    - **9minsters.Minster of war, public works ,agriculture, finance , Justice , Pen, the Palace, commerce and foreign affairs and the interior**.
    - 1908 Lij Iyasu as his successor

5.1.2. The Plans of Fascist Italy

- Italian colonial interest in Ethiopia rise when **Mussolini and his Fascist to** power in 1922.

- A combination of factors drove them in to aggression against Ethiopia.
  - The cause of aggression was the desire ***to erase the shameful scare*** as a result of their defeated at Adwa in 1896.
  - Fascist advocated the restoration of power & glory of ancient Rome ,they had to take **revenge and erase the sense of shame**.
  - Mussolini also wanted to win prestige for himself through a military success.

- In 1923 Ethiopia entered to the league of nation Italy did not oppose this membership as the British did.
- In 1924 Ras *Teferi tour Europe*, he received **warm welcome in Italy .**
- Italy signed a **peace and friendship relation with Ethiopia in 1928**.
  - These moves served the Fascists to cover their real plans right up to the eve of the invasion

- Fascist preparation **consisted two main activities**
  - **Subversive** measures and **Military** preparations
- **First Subversive measures** means seeking or intended to subvert on established system or institution **creating internal division** in Ethiopia.
  - It was carried by **Corrado Zoli (Italian governor of Eritrea**).
  - Corrado Zoli bribed and agitated the chiefs of Tigray,Wollo, Begemider& Gojjam to against the Emperor

- ***2nd Military preparation*,**
  - Italy put in a place armies and war supplies in her colonies of Eretria and Italian Somali land.
  - Italy military prepared since the end of Battle of Adwa for revenge.
- **By 1932 Britain and France** had made the *Hoare-lavel agreement* by which they offered Italy to take Ethiopia.
  - This was done to encourage Italy not to ally with **Nazi Germany**

- On 5, Dec, 1934 Ethiopia and Italian troops clashed at **Walwal in Ogaden.** In the Ethiopia territory.
  - According to the 1908 boundary treaty between Ethiopia and Italy, Walwal was part of Ethiopia
- In the clash Ethiopia side which suffered more casualties
  - But Italians demanded that Ethiopia should make an **official apology** & pay compensation.
- Ethiopia tried its best to solve the ***disputes by peaceful arbitration & applied to league of nation***. But league was not solving the problem.
- League only decided for economic sanction ***that did not include oil. Because league*** dominated by Britain and France.

N.B. **Ethiopia was not prepared to war** with stand Italian aggression after the battle of **Adwa**.

- Ethiopian government did not pay attention to build a modern army.

- Mussolini started a **full scale invasion** against Ethiopia almost a year after the **Walwal incident.**
  - Haile Selassie reliance on the League of Nations and its principle of collective security also proved to be useless.

5.2 .<u>The Italo -Ethiopian war ,1935-1936</u>

- Fascist Italy's war on Ethiopia was a war of colonial aggression against an independent state and a member of League of Nations. **It was unjust war**
  - It violated the natural and democratic rights of the Ethiopian people.
- The Fascist invasion of Ethiopia was carried out on **two fronts**.
  - North front (from Eritrea) &
  - South front (from Italian- Somali land)

North Front /Italian side/

- When the war started in the North front, the commander in chief of all Italian force was **Emilio de Bono.**
  - Later replaced by General **Pietro Badoglio in Nov. 1936.**
- The North front invasion began October 3, 1935 Italian troops crossed ***Mereb river concurred Ethiopia***
- Ethiopian army was **ordered to pull back & did not try to cheek** the advancing of Fascist army due to the following two reasons ;-
  - 1st to show the Italian aggressors to the world and
  - 2nd to form the Strategic point of view

South Front/Italian side/

- The commander of the Fascist army on the southern front was General **Rudolf Graziani**
  - At the beginning his assignments was to stop any possible Ethiopian offensive **against Italian Somali** land**.**
  - Because of this ,the first invasion began on the North Front.

5.2.1. The Northern Front

- The Ethiopian army of the Northern Front consisted **three major divisions.**
  - The 1st division was **under Ras Imiru's Shire front**
  - 2nd division Ras **Seyoum Mengeshea and Ras Kassa Hailu** took the center to fought **Temben front.**
  - 3rd division, the right flank on the Mountaintop known as **Amba Aradom front,** was taken by the imperial army under the command of **Ras Mulugeta yigezu** (Aged war minister).

N.B *Ras* ***Kassa Hailu*** the overall command of the north front.

- Ethiopian army opened up counter offensive on major towns of ***Adigrat,Adwa,&Makele***.
  - In the first counter-offensive Ethiopian troops mainly attempted to encircle the Italians in the strategic town of Mekele
- The first battle of Temben was fought **between 20 - 24 January 1936.**
  - In this battle, the forces of **Ras Kassa Hailu and Seyoum Mengesha** were defeated by Fascist.
  - About 8,000 Ethiopian died &wounded. From Italy 60officers,605soliders & 417 Askeris killed & wounded.
  - The Ethiopian force were unable to dislodge the Italians from Mekele ,nor could they stop the **advance of Fascists.**

- The Advance made by Fascist did not satisfy **Mussolini** who wanted to complete the Ethiopian campaign before the beginning of the **rainy season**. He replaced **De bono** by **Badoglio**.
  - Then Badogilo started the use of the internationally ***banned Mustard gas*** the killer gas, (yipright as known as in its scientific name).
  - Following the first battle of Temben ,**Amba Aradom** became the next target of the Fascist force.

- ,Ras Mulugata led 80,000 troops. At this battle Italian use Massive attack & bombardment.
  - The destructive effect of the ground and aerial attack between **February 10-15/1936,forced** the Ethiopian troops to evacuate the **Mountain top** leaving behind about 6000 killed.
  - **Ras Mulugeta** himself was killed in the course that disorganized retreat
  - At this battle from Italian side only 36 white officer ,621 white soldiers & 145 Askaris troops were killed and wounded.

- **February1936**, the second battle of Temben Ras Kassa & Seyoum fought the Italians.
  - They could not with stand the numerically and tactically effective.
- The commanders themselves with their few remaining soldiers ,barely escaped from **Italian siege** and joined the Emperor stationed at **Korem in Noth Wollo** .
  - In the second battle of **Temben 8,000 Ethiopian** were killed& wounded.
  - Italian side 34 officers,350 soldiers of lower rank & 1880 Eritrean Askaris were killed and wounded.

- **Shire front Ras Imiru** had performed relatively better than other front.
  - Imiru's destroyed **Luigi Crinit** force strategic pass of **Dembeguna**.
- How ever, Ras Imiru's force was not free from problems and it lost the battle of Shire front April 2,1936.
  - Problem rise from poor farming moral from the nobility of Gojam & Semen. They disliked Emperor
  - Ras Imiru was successful in making an organized retreat towards lake Ashenge with an army of some 10,000 men.

- The battle took place between March 31 and April 11,1936 **Seyoum and Kassa** were unable to make any difference in the battle
  - The army of Ras Mulugeta had already been put out of the action after Amba Aradom.
  - Ras Imiru's army ,which was relatively in good shape ,did not part in the battle of Maychew.

- The last & decisive battle in the North Front was fought at **Maychew** on 31 *March , 1936* .
  - Ethiopian troops led by Emperor Haile Selassie I.
  - Only fresh force in the Ethiopian army was the imperial bodyguard with some 6000 men
  - After 13hr continuous war with Fascist force the Ethiopian army lost battle.
- This was followed **by Bombings and Showers of** mustard gas from air that led to retreating Ethiopian army.

- It is believed that 5000 to 8000 Ethiopians were killed at Mychew
- On the Italian side ,68 white officers,332 white soldiers and 873 Eritrean Askaris were killed and wounded
- In April 1936 Fascist entered **Dessie** with out any opposition .
- The north side struggle was particularly fail.

5.2.2. The Southern Front

- Italian General **Rodolfo Graziani(his neck name Hyena of Libya)**
  - ⇨ In the south Graziani could not stand missing the glories of Fascist victory
  - ⇨ He repeatedly asked Mussolini by **Telegrams to get permission** to offensive attack in the south.
- ❖ Total troops of Ethiopia 80,000 in this front.
- Ethiopia troops made up of two- sub divisions
  - Ψ Southern – **Ras Desta Damtew** ruler of –Sidamo and
  - Ψ South Eastern- **Dejjazmach Nasibu Zamanuel** governer of Hararge province
- The Ethiopian armies on both side were relatively better armed and supplied than the North Front.

- Graziani's first attack was directed against **Qorahe in the Ogaden**. **Qorahe** was a strategically situated place to moves against **Jijiga and Harar** towns.
    - Ethiopian army had stronghold on Qoarhe under Commander ***Grazmach Afework*** tries to defend in this strategically place, but **fatally wounded**. November **1935 Qorahe fell** under Fascist troops.
    - The only challenge the Fascist met this advance was from the Ethiopian army under **Dejazmach Mekonnen Endalkachew.**

- Ras Desta force reduce the pressure of **Fascist in Ogaden Front** .But Ras Desta committed a fatal mistake in ordering a disastrous campaign to **Dolo Odo,** in Ethio- somali border.
  - The long march through a desert land ,and under shortage of provisions ,combined with epidemic disease destroyed almost half of **Ras Desta's army**.
  - At the battle of **Genale Dorya** on January 26, 1936 Italian army defeated Ethiopian army. The hard fighting continued for three day .Ethiopian force was totally routed
  - **On January 20 1936 Negele Borena** was captured by the Italians. Ras Desta retreated to the interior part of the country with few soldiers to continue resistance.

5.2.3 Italian victory

☎ In the campaign of 1935/36 Ethiopian force totally defeated by Fascist. May 5,1936 Fascist troops entered to Addis Ababa.

- **Factors of Fascist Victory**

Italian side

- Fascist army numerically and technically superior.
- Equipped modern armament.
- used tanks and poisoned gas
- Fascist used 400 air places for the war.

Ethiopian side

- 1.Ethiopian used out dated guns
  - Shortage of cartridges and used only eight transport planes.
- 2.Ethiopian had no organized system of military logistics.
- 3.There were difference and dissatisfaction with in the Ethiopian army. This was the result of policy of Haile Selassie to strength the central government which was weaken the power of regional lords
  - For example ,**Dejach Haile Selassie Gugsa** a son in law of of emperor and governor-general of Tigray and **Ras Kassa** rivalry weakened the army.

- Ras Mulugeta unhappy with the Emperor for the reason that the Emperor appointed Ras Kassa as a commander in chief of the northern army.
  - As war minster ,Ras Mulugeta felt that the post should have been given to him.

- 4.Finally many of the commanders of Ethiopian army were the old nobility with little knowledge of modern warfare.

- Following the battle of Maychew ,the Emperor ordered a retreat in the direction of the capital
  - Emperor and senior officials sat to discuss what to do next.

- Following Maychew battle long discussion between the soldiers Emperor and war general
  - After discussion decided that the **Emperor should leave the country to appeal in a person to league of nation.**
  - As regard the future of the country officers agreed to setup a provisional government at **Gore(Illubabor),** with acting head **Ras Imiru (Cousin of Emperors**)

- Accordingly ,the Emperor and *his family ,togather with a few members nobility and sinior officals left country for Europe on the Franco- Ethiopian Railway May 3, 1936.*
- Emperor appealed to the League of Nations through a power full speech, he made in front of delegates from members country at Geneva.
    - The Emperor remained an exile in England to got support.
- He warned that not defending Ethiopia would encourage aggression against others. But no response. Emperor remained in exile in England, but got support since 1940.
    - N.B.Fascist troops led Pietro Badoglio captured Addis Ababa may 5, 1936.

- Generally today we have seen about :-
  - **Background and causes of the Italo-Ethiopian war of 1935-1936**
  - **The Italo-Ethiopian war,1935-1936**

Questions

1. Why were Italians able to defeat the Ethiopian army in both the North and southern Fronts?
2. List the Ethiopian war general in the North and south front
3. Why were the Italians able to win the war of 1935-1936,unlike the 1896 battle of Adwa
4. Why did the League of Nation fail to defend Ethiopia?
5. How did Emperor Menelik II responded the Tripartite Treaty?
6. Why was Ras Desta Dametew's campaign of Dolo Odo a mistake?

History Grade -12
Unit- Five 9(cont.)

Italian Fascists Aggression Against Ethiopia (1935-1941)

5.3.Fascist Occupation and Patriotic Resistance 1936-1941.

5.4. The War of Liberation and Ethiopian Independence

- **After the end of this lesson you will be able to:-**
  - Explain about Italian occupations and war of liberation of Ethiopia
  - List the Ethiopian patriotic leaders
  - Point out the scarifies paid by Ethiopian resistance fighters
  - Explain ,how did Ethiopian patriotism manifest itself in war with Italy

5.3.Fascist occupation and patriotic resistance

5.3.1.Colonial administration

- Fascist rule in Ethiopia lasted for five years. Italian East Africa was **divided into six regions** with their respective capital.
  - Eritrea (include Tigray)- Asmara
  - Amhara (Begemider, Wollo, Gojjam, N. Shoa)-Gonder
  - Oromo- Sidama- Jimma
  - Addis ababa (Shoa)- Addis Ababa
  - Harar- Harar.
  - Italian Somaliland(including Ogaden)- Mogadisho

- Each of the six regions had its own Governor -General.
- The highest authority in Italian East Africa was held by **Mussolini's viceroy** who lived in the ***Gunete-Leul palace (now Addis Ababa University***).
    - Addis Ababa was the **center of Italian East Africa.**
- Mussolini's viceroy are the following orderly;-
    - 1st –Pietro Badoglio
    - 2nd- Rodolfo Graziani
    - 3rd- Amado Umberto (the Duke of Aosta)
- The last one considered as **more liberal- minded** than those before him.

- During the years of Italian occupations ,Fascist authority in Ethiopia was largely confined to the urban centers.
  - The Fascist introduced electric city, new road and pure water to the city
  - **Merkato** serve as a commercial center .Before ***Merkato commercial center of Addis Abbaba was Arada***
  - Cotton & cement factory established at ***Dire Dawa***.

5.3.2. The patriotic resistance

- Fascist authority largely limited to **urban centers**
- The rural (country side) areas were the centers of ***national liberation struggle.***
- The patriotic resistance movement developed into two distinct stages.
  - 1st phase lasted until February, 1937.
- The prominent leaders of the resistance of the early phase were high ranking nobility
  - Ras Desta Dametew
  - Ras Imiru Hailesellassie
  - Abera Kassa and
  - Asfawossen Kassa

- Educated Ethiopian, soldiers & officers by agreement set up "**Black lion" organization**. In order to continue the resistance
  - The organization's military leaders were: -
    - Ψ Lieutenant Colonels Belay Haileab
    - Ψ Kifle Nesibu and
    - Ψ Ketema Beshah
    - Ras Imiru was forced to take leadership of the movements and to strike on Fascists in Addis Ababa.

- Ras Imiru's organized troops from **Wollaga& Illubabor** to entered Addis Ababa but they were defeated ***near Gojeb river*** by Fascist.
- **Another leader of Anti-Fascist** was **Ras Desta Dametew** also obtained some assistance from patriotic force. From Dejjazamach **Beyne Merid** and Dejazmach **GebreMariam Gari**.
  - Ras Desta was defeated by force of Fascist at Gogeti (in village of Gurage)feb,1937.
  - Fascist captured Ras Desta & killed him ***at Butajira town publically executed*** him by a firing squad.
- The two sons of Ras Kassa ,**abera and Asfawosen** became famous for taking part in the abortive attacking in Addis Ababa

- The attacking of Fascist, by Ethiopian patriots planned into 4 directions in Addis Ababa
  - North of Addis Ababa---Abera Kassa and Asfawosen Kasa (sons of Ras kassa Hailu)
  - South of AddisAbaba------Adwa hero Dejjazmach *Balcha Safo.*
  - North west of Addis Ababa-------Ras Abebe Aragay and
  - East of Addis Ababa ----------Dejjazmach Fiqre -Mariam Yinadu
    - The Bishop of **Wollo ,Abuna Petros ,** an outspoken anti Fascist patriot was a moving sprit behind the plan.
    - But the attack was poorly planned and lacked effective coordination and timing.

- Abuna Petros caught of publically executed **on 29,July 1936**.
- **Abera and Asfa –wossen** retreated to Selale to the north of Addis Ababa.
  - Afterwards they were **persuaded by Ras Hailu Tekle-Haymanot,** the leading Fascist collaborator, who promised them they would not be killed, **to surrender to Fascists**
    - But Italian (Fascist) not keep the promise killed the two brothers on **21 december,1936.**
  - Dejjazmach Balcha was killed while fighting the fascist in the southern part of Addis Ababa. At the place he was killed a memorial hospital ,**Dejjazmach Balcha Hospital** was late constructed and still bears his name.

❖ 2nd phase of Patriotic resistance

- It was marked by the outcome of an abortive attempt to kill Marshal Graziani. **February19, 1937**.
  - The action was taken by **Abraha Deboch** and **Mogos Asgdom.**
  - In a public gathering called at the Guenete le'ul place celebrating the birthday of Italian prince (now Addis Ababa University).

- The two young men threw a bomb on Graziani and other colonial officers. Graziani wounded & some officers were died.
- Then followed a whole sale massacre by **fascist troops and Askaris** inside and around Addis Ababa **for three days February 19-21,1937.**
  - Educated Ethiopians were main target of massacre.
    - This act almost totally destroyed the first generation of modern educated Ethiopians.
    - About 30,000 Ethiopians were killed in the massacre
  - 499 Monks are reported to have been killed at monastery of **Debre Libanos**.

- The Graziani massacre resulted in the outbreak of a country wide anti-fascist patriotic resistance in the second phase.
- Guerilla warfare increase in the country side like in
  - Shoa ,Gojjam ,Gonder ,Begamdir etc
- The patriots employed various tactics with final goals of bringing an end Fascist rule
  - The tactics include *Ambush of enemy convoys, Cutting communication lions and at times Striking* Fascist force
- The patriots faced lack of sufficient **supplies & logistics.**

- ***Yewist Arbegnoch*** Contribute many thing to patriots in the ways of struggle by giving information to patriots. Their supporters who liked and worked with the enemy.
  - They also gave medical supply and other assistance
- **For example: *Shewarged Gedle*** (in Addis Alem Town)
  - She helped the patriots greatly
  - She preparing favorable condition for patriots
  - N.B. Between **1937 and 1941** ,more than **one million Lire** was spent for military purpose in the colonies each year by the **Italian government**.

- The patriotic resistance contributed in a great deal in weaking the Fascists, which were finally defeated and forced to surrender in 1941.
- Some of the famous leaders of the patriots were: -
  - Ras Abebe Argay
  - Bekele Woya
  - Geresu Duki
  - Belay Zeleke Lakew
  - Amoraw Wubneh and
  - Takel W/Hawariat

- The two Ethiopian nationals
  - **Zerai Deres**
    - He killed the Italian Fascist soldiers at square in their own country.
    - He was died in 1937 at Rome
  - **Abdisa Aga**
    - He conducted a long fight against the fascist in their own country.
    - He was prisoner of war in the island **of Sicily** also showed exemplary patriotism in Italy itself in the time of World War II by against Fascist force.

Banda's (collaborated to Italy)

- Ras Hailu Teklehaymanot of Gojjam,
- Seyum Mengesha of Tigray,
- Ayallew Biru of Semen &
- Aba Jobir of Jimma

5.4. The war of liberation and Ethiopian independence

- In 1940 an event of great importance for the liberation of Ethiopia occurred in Europe.
  - This was **Italy entry in to World War II** on the side of Germany
  - On June10, 1940, Italy declared war on Britain and France. Only four days before the fall of Paris in to German hands.
- Italy's entry in to the war on the side of Hitler's become a serious danger to British interest in East Africa. **British colonies**; Kenya, Sudan, Uganda, Zanzibar, Tanganyika and British Somaliland.
- In the same region ,Italy also had a vast colonial Empire .*Italy had 200,000 troops in the East African Empire.*

- Britain feared that ,with the help of Hitler's army ,Italy would expand in East Africa and takeaway its colonies
    - Britain had to act quickly and drive out Italian forces from East Africa.
    - British government had ignored Emperor Haile Selassie's request for military assistance before Italy entered to the war
    - British government began to supply military assistance to the Ethiopian patriots in the preparation of final campaign in East Africa.
- The Soba military academy was opened to train Ethiopian officers in Sudan.
    - British government also arranged for **Haile Selassie's** move by air to Sudan

- Emperor gave instruction to anti –fascist patriotic resistance in Ethiopia .
- Britain started assistance to the Ethiopian force in the following direction to drive away Italian from East Africa ;-
  - 1st from Sudan the British army under **General Platt** made an offensive against Fascist forces in Eritrea.
    - The major theatre of the war in Eretria was Italian **stronghold of Keren .**
      - **It** fell in to the hands of British force after 53 days of struggle that cause heavy damage on both side.

- 2nd another British Force from Sudan accompanied the Emperor in to Gojjam in the Western Ethiopia.
  - ⇨ This was the ***Gedeon force,*** under its commander's **colonel Dan Sanford** and Major Orde **Charles Wingate**. After crossing the border of Ethiopia.
    - These force were joined by different groups of Ethiopian patriots
    - The combine force fought the Fascist troops in Gonder and Gojjam & continued fighting all along their way to Addis Ababa.

- 3rd major British force was organized in Kenya ,under the commander of **General Cunningham.**
  - ⇨ He was made a quick advance in to Italian Somali land and then to Harar and forced Italians to surrender.
  - ⇨ The British army under **General Cunningham** and the patriotic force drove Fascist troops out of **Addis Ababa on 6 April, 1941.**
  - ⇨ Ethiopia was liberated by combined force of Britain and Ethiopian patriots.
- After a month later on **May 5, 1941 Haile Selassie** victoriously **re-**entered Addis Ababa .Ethiopia was liberated after five years of Fascist rule.

- Generally today we have seen about
  - **Fascist Occupation and patriotic Resistance ,1936-1941.**
  - **The war of Liberation and Ethiopian Independence**

Questions

1.What was the role "Black Lion" Organization during the time of Italo- Ethiopian war?

2.List the known Ethiopian patriots

3.Mention the British war general supported the Ethiopian force during the time of war of liberations

4.How were the Italians driven out from Ethiopia after their five years of occupation?

5.What was the role of Emperor Haile Selassie in the patriotic resistance movement between 1936 and 1941?

6.List the British war leader assisted Ethiopian in the time of war of Liberation against Italy

7.Why did Grazani massacre Ethiopian since February 1937?